

Research On Sound Usage in Narrative Through Game Design.

Kenospic After Wars: A Multiplayer First Person Shooter

Sound in all games of all types is a key element into expression of mood. It helps us really sell the feeling and externalize something that cannot be done visually.

Good sound that compliments good visual direction into something that feels great.

Often it is overlooked in specific genres of games that aren't considered as expressive as others. Story games aren't naturally more expressive than shooter games on the mere fact that they are story/narrative games. People often ignore that every element that travels through time in a certain space carries a narrative of sorts. This narrative is not always visually available to showcase or express, sometimes or often not even possible. This is where sound plays a beautiful role in showing us things we haven't seen. Explaining a story that we don't know existed. A past of an object we are very unaware of and at times stay unaware of.

To enhance my point, I would like to reference the sound of a flyby bullet. There is a saying, If you hear the crack or whizz of a bullet, it was either not aimed directly at you or it missed you by close proximity. This itself is a little narrative, we don't see it as a narrative though, a story of a bullet that has just missed the POV of the character.

This isn't all, every object that moves or can be moved has a story. Not all of this story is shown and somehow needs to be heard through along with the visuals to be made aware of.

When done right, this really drives our art direction in the right place.

Research

Tom Wright Sound, Islands of Nyne:BR. (2018). *How To Make Awesome Gunshot Sounds for Games - Fully Automatics*. [online]

www.youtube.com. Available at: <https://youtu.be/-Cw36ilGfns>.

 How To Make Awesome Gunshot Sounds for Games - Fully Automatics (feat. Islands o...

This video is a great example of telling a story through sound. At Exactly 3:20 of this video, the creator explains how the bullet hitting a wooden box in itself is a story for sound to convey and compliment the visual scene. The sounds of a good gun shot convey the information we don't see, such as the bullet shell falling onto a certain material. This in itself is a novel narrative of sorts. It subconsciously makes the player aware of things they aren't aware of or gives them a sense of spatial recognition.

Average Pixel(2020). *Satisfying Reloads | The Art in Reload Animations*.

[online] Available at: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ym_mNU6DWK8.

 Satisfying Reloads | The Art in Reload Animations

At 14:05, Average pixel talks of how sound design, something that doesn't fall in the hands of the animator, drives the animation itself.

The sound conveys a lot of information that players do not see in an action as simple as reloading their weapon- such being a narrative or story within itself. The foley of internal mechanics of guns, the sounds of the cloth that wraps around the body, its folds. These sounds convey how heavy the gun is to handle, how many internal parts it consists of and what the pace of the scene is. Almost a spatial recognition of awareness of the internal structure of the weapon being used.

Also something that makes the "story" of a weapon reload very satisfying.

McGee, M. (2020). *How Great Horror Sounds Are Made || Waveform*.

[online] www.youtube.com. Available at:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TFLWaTG0NTM>.

This video is a great study and showcase of how sounds and its attributes set the atmosphere and externalize / project onto the player what it is, they must feel. It also showcases how the sound absorption in a certain setting gives us an insight to the room or space we are in. It sets the suspense and tone for us to expect something. Sound works GREAT for a horror setting, but saying that almost makes me contradict my first point of how all narratives (or not narratives) depend on sound just as equally.

For my final 2 references, part of the same project and deeply influential onto my project:

Danrify(2021). *Battlefield 1 Voice Actors carry weight for German voice recordings (English CC updated)*. [online] Available at:

 Battlefield 1 Voice Actors carry weight for German voice recordings (E...

yahoolinovich909. *When the end of round theme hits - battlefield 1*.

[online] Available at: <https://www.youtube.com/shorts/pV1n5y-9uFg>.

Metrobes. (2026). *The end of round music in Battlefield 1 is so GOOD*.

Available at: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=13mbdhmTp_U

 The end of round music in Battlefield 1 is SO GOOD.

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Battlefield 1 for me has to be the most inspirational piece of art. The game in my opinion, is perfection in every little detail. The voice acting of the game was made in accordance to the scene- how far something is or what it is that the character is currently “feeling”. The music that drives behind

the gameplay is an absolute cherry on the top, it compliments the gameplay heavily based on realtime data. If you are the team losing, the music and its pitch really drives up your senses and makes you feel stressed, it pushes you to do more. When the match is about to end, the music paces up and you are in full awareness of the seriousness of the situation, everyone and everything becomes more chaotic and the music keeps pushing you in that direction. This all, if anything is

NARRATIVE

“Rick Altman said that while most listeners have learned to ignore inconsistencies in sound playback, “a proper theory of sound will accept no such selective deafness” (1992, 30) Film theorist Michel Chion agreed, stating that even though we are easily convinced by audio-visual media “this does not mean that it is wrong to aspire to a better simulacrum” (1994, 96). Our ability to suspend disbelief and only pay attention to the aspects of sound which meet our expectations is not actually a get-out-of-jail-free card for video game acoustics. There are numerous subconscious perceptual cues that are provided by different aspects of acoustics which contribute to our experience in various ways. By removing aspects of sound behaviour simply because we wouldn’t notice their absence, we risk damaging the player’s experience by failing to provide functional perceptual cues of which the player is not actively aware. Understanding the difference between perception and awareness is crucial for a video game sound designer when they are working on the acoustics for a virtual space. The research presented here studies video game acoustics all the way down to the raw perception level, ascertaining aspects of acoustics that are fundamental to the natural experience of sound.”

Probert and Kym, B. (2020). *Video Game Acoustics: Perception-Based Sound Design for Interactive Virtual Spaces*. [online] Available at: <https://digital.library.adelaide.edu.au/server/api/core/bitstreams/438232fb-f972-4589-ab62-5dacedd391a6/content>.

This paper here is an amazing read on how we perceive sound and how we must compute them for games. It is important to understand how much we hear and what we hear to make what must be heard.

Implementation

Kenospic as a war based game will simulate narrative through sound in all actions and atmospheres.

Every weapon features foley sounds that resemble its weight. Vehicles feature engine sounds with distance variations individually hand crafted to suit the distance and setting of the vehicle itself. This isn't it, the physical condition of the vehicle, what exists inside the vehicle also makes noise.

When you crouch, when you slide and when you vault - the clothes fold. The character exhales air.

Yes, this is getting too deep into the details but it isn't technically hard to do at all and I am trying to push toward the idea of finishing systems one by one and setting them aside.

Something interesting that Kenospic also features is - Narrations. Pre war speeches, sometimes given by the players. VOIP is open to the world that pushes towards creating more authentic social experiences.

The game also strives for narration by an announcer, just to keep a tab onto the actual score.

The music is well synced with the state of the match and individual team's score.

The game features a sound on being hit, different when on foot and when in a vehicle. A casino draw sound when you score a kili which is almost weird in thought but satisfying in place. A hitmarker sound different for hitting the body and different for a headshot.

This however, is NOT a testament to realism. If anything, I strive to make the game more artistic than realistic (yes realistic itself is artistic in some sense but I prefer not relating to predicted human standards for interaction, rather make something unconsciously more satisfying.)

Kenospic will stand as a reflection to how a sense of underlying realism, or if not realism then urbanism can be complimented with contrasting direction in artistic choices.

Certain parameters are set in design for the decision of what makes a sound belong in a place.

Do we really work that way though - we rather construct actions and elements without sound then start deconstructing them at each stage and point where it must be involved and what story must really be told.

This overview explains the general use of sound in Kenospic and a study around why it will be used the way it does. How do we conclude to certain parameters that establish consistency and cohesiveness and make a piece of work belong with the other.

The only question that remains for me to really work around is, how would I technically stand out?

Do I need to? No, I don't NEED to but I do wish to try.